Ashelz Bible App: what is left to publish on Google Play

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Please read first. The steps and numbers below are what was known when this was written (October 2026). Google changes its rules often, so check each Play Console screen as you go. Nothing here is legal advice, and nothing claims approval by Google or any other body. How privacy and data laws apply is to be confirmed with the relevant legal bodies, authorities and entities of Namibia.

1. Already done (no action needed)

	Item	Where
✔	The app itself: Bible reader, daily devotion, prayers, notes, journal, Homecell, Creator Studio for Ashelz, profile pictures, translations	The live app, version 2.4.31
✔	Privacy Policy page and Delete my data page (in the app and on the web)	`privacy.html` and `privacy.html?delete` on the app address
✔	Store listing text: name, short description (71 of 80 characters), full description	`docs/play-store/store_listing.md`
✔	Data safety answers, content rating answers (drafts)	`data_safety.md`, `content_rating.md`
✔	Graphics: 512 icon, 1024×500 banner, six 1080×1920 phone screenshots	`docs/play-store/graphics/`
✔	Closed test kit and Android packaging guide, assetlinks template	`closed_test.md`, `android_wrapper.md`, `assetlinks.template.json`

2. Before anything else: check the live app (about 30 minutes)

	Task	Who	How and what to look for
☐	Confirm the live site is built from the repository that holds the latest version	You	Open the app, then About, and check it says **Version 2.4.31** (or higher). In GitHub, open the repository, Settings, Pages, and confirm the site source. If the version is older, the site is not receiving the latest files.
☐	Open the privacy page in a browser	You	Visit `…/Ashelz-Bible-App/privacy.html` and `…/privacy.html?delete`. Both must load without a login. Google needs a public link.

☐	Test the three untested live services once	You	In Bible Translations, tap **Show all languages** and read a chapter; tap **Show Biblia versions** and read a chapter. Both were tested here only with pretend copies of the services. Tell the developer anything that fails.
☐	Restrict the Biblia.com key	You	In your Biblia.com account, set the key's **Application URL** to `https://ashelzbible.github.io/Ashelz-Bible-App/` so other sites cannot reuse it.
☐	Check the app on a real phone offline	You	Open a KJV chapter, switch on airplane mode, close and reopen the app. The reader should still work.
☐	Make sure Ashelz's publishing works	Ashelz	Post a short text test in Creator Studio, check it shows on Devotions, then delete it.

3. The Google Play developer account (days, mostly waiting)

	Task	Who	Details
☐	Create the account	You	Go to play.google.com/console and sign in with a Google account you will keep for years. Choose **Personal** (no company needed). Pay the one time fee, about US$25.
☐	Enter the developer name exactly	You	**Loren-Ashlyn Van Rensburg**. It must match your ID, and it shows publicly on the store page.
☐	Verify identity, phone and email	You	Google asks for a government ID, a phone number, and the support email. This can take a few days. Keep the ID ready.
☐	Check the public contact details	You	A personal account shows a contact address and email publicly. The email chosen is ashlyn.dekoe1@gmail.com. Decide what address you are comfortable showing.
☐	Note any new Android developer verification rule	You	Google has been introducing extra developer verification for Android apps. Read the notice in Play Console and follow it if it applies to you.

4. Make the website check file (assetlinks), staying on this domain

Google verifies that the Android app and the website belong together using a file at the **root** of the domain, `https://ashelzbible.github.io/.well-known/assetlinks.json`. The app sits in a sub folder, so it needs a small second repository.

	Task	Who	Details
☐	Create a repository named exactly `ashelzbible.github.io`	You	In the GitHub account **ashelzbible**. Make it public and turn on GitHub Pages (Settings, Pages, deploy from the main branch).
☐	Add `.nojekyll` and `.well-known/assetlinks.json`	You (the developer can write the file)	Use `assetlinks.template.json`. Put in the package name and the fingerprint (see step 6). Keep the file name exact.
☐	Open the address in a browser	You	The JSON must appear on screen. If it does not, the Android check will fail and a browser bar will show at the top of the app.

5. Package the app as an Android file (.aab)

	Task	Who	Details
☐	Choose the package name	You	Suggested: `io.github.ashelzbible.bible`. It can never be changed after the first upload.
☐	Build with PWABuilder (easiest)	You	At pwabuilder.com paste the app address, choose Package for stores, Android, Google Play. Download the zip.
☐	Keep the signing key and its password safe	You	The zip contains a signing key. Copy it and the password somewhere safe in two places. If you lose them you cannot update the app.
☐	Write down the SHA-256 fingerprint	You	It is shown in the zip's instructions. After the first upload, use the **app signing key** fingerprint from Play Console, Setup, App signing, in assetlinks.json, because Google re-signs the app.
☐	Alternative if Google calls it a "web wrapper"	Developer	Bundle the app files inside an Android app with Capacitor. Ask the developer to prepare it.

6. Create the app in Play Console and fill the forms

	Task	Who	Details
☐	Create app	You	Name: Ashelz Bible App. Language: English. App (not game). **Free**. Accept the declarations.

☐	Main store listing	You	Copy from `store_listing.md`. Upload the icon, the banner and the phone screenshots from the graphics folder. Add the website and the support email.
☐	Privacy policy link	You	`https://ashelzbible.github.io/Ashelz-Bible-App/privacy.html`
☐	Data safety form	You	Use `data_safety.md`. Use the delete page link for data deletion.
☐	Content rating questionnaire	You	Use `content_rating.md`. Only you can submit it.
☐	Target audience	You	General audience, not designed for children.
☐	Ads declaration, app access, other declarations	You	Ads: **No**. App access: all features available without login. Answer the news, health, government, and financial feature questions honestly, which should all be **No**.
☐	Countries and pricing	You	Choose where to offer the app. Namibia plus any others you want. Price: free.
☐	Tablet screenshots (if asked)	Developer	Only needed if you want the app featured on tablets. Ask the developer to make 7 and 10 inch screenshots.

7. Closed test, then production (at least 14 days)

	Task	Who	Details
☐	Upload the .aab to a Closed testing track	You	Play Console, Testing, Closed testing, Create track. Upload the file and save, then submit it for review.
☐	Gather at least 12 testers	You	Friends, family, and church members with Android phones and Gmail addresses. Aim for 15 to 20. Add their emails to the testers list. Use the message in `closed_test.md`.
☐	Testers install from Play and stay opted in	Testers	They must accept the invite, install the app, and keep it installed for **14 days in a row**. Track them with the table in `closed_test.md`.
☐	Fix anything testers report	Developer	Send problems and screenshots to the developer. Fixes reach testers as a new version.
☐	Apply for production	You	After the test period, open the Dashboard and tap Apply for production. Answer the questions about your testing honestly.
☐	Create the production release and submit	You	Upload the same .aab, add release notes, and send it for review. Reviews can take from a few days to a few weeks for a new account.

8. After the app is live

- Update the app: when the web app changes, the Android app updates itself, because it opens the website. Only changes to the package (icon, package settings) need a new .aab.
- Reply to reviews and keep the support email watched.
- Keep the privacy policy true: if the app starts to collect data, add ads or analytics, update the policy and the Data safety form first.
- Renew the GitHub publishing token before it expires, so Ashelz can keep posting.
- Only after the app is on Google Play, add a Google Play badge to the app or the website. Until then keep store badges out.

9. Things that commonly delay approval

- The developer name or the contact details do not match the ID you uploaded.
- The privacy link does not open, or the policy says something different from the Data safety form.
- The app is judged a plain website wrapper. Say it has its own features (reader, prayers, journal, notes, devotions, Homecell) and offer the Capacitor version if needed.
- Copyrighted text. Use only versions the app is licensed to show. The NIV is only available through a service key that includes it.
- The testers drop out before day 14. Start with more than 12.

10. Quick summary: who does what

You (Loren-Ashlyn)	Ashelz or testers	The developer
• Pay for and set up the Play account, ID check • Create the `ashelzbible.github.io` repository • Build and keep the signing key safe • Fill every Play Console form and upload • Apply for production	• Ashelz: test posting, check devotions • 12 or more testers: install and stay opted in for 14 days	• Fix bugs from testing • Write assetlinks.json with your fingerprint • Capacitor version if Google asks for it • Tablet screenshots, updated graphics

Source files for everything above are in the repository folder `docs/play-store/`.